

Image Of God

doc-image-of-god

Anthropology · Imago Dei · doctrine · unanimous_lineages

AFFIRMS

score 0.963
confidence high

Statement under examination

All human beings are created in the image of God (imago Dei), bearing inherent dignity, moral agency, rationality, and capacity for relationship with God, irrespective of age, ability, ethnicity, or stage of development.

In plain language

Genesis 1:26-27 says God made humanity (adam) in his image (tselem) and according to his likeness (demuth), and applies this to male and female together. Both nouns carry the ending *our*, so the text reads in our image, after our likeness. The same word for image grounds the murder prohibition in Genesis 9:6, where the causal because in the image of God he made humanity shows the image survives the fall and belongs to every person whose life is protected. Psalm 8 restates the dignity in royal language, and James 3:9 says humans have been made according to the likeness of God, using a perfect-tense verb that marks this as a settled, enduring condition of every person, then forbids cursing them on that basis. Colossians 3:10 speaks of being renewed in knowledge according to the image of the Creator, echoing Genesis. Across Law, Writings, and apostolic letters the same vocabulary keeps saying the image is true of humanity as such, with no limit by age, ability, ethnicity, or stage of development. So the proposition that all humans bear God's image is strongly supported. Where readers diverge is not whether humans bear the image but what the image consists of. The Hebrew word *tselem* most often names a physical representation or statue, the word *demuth* means resemblance and is used elsewhere for visionary likenesses, and the command to have dominion is joined to the image clause as a following purpose rather than as its definition. Because the words name a representation without spelling out its inner content, the text leaves honest room for three readings: the image as a created endowment of human nature, the image as a capacity for relationship, and the image as a royal calling to represent God by ruling. Each fits the words. The vocabulary affirms the image clearly but does not rank these accounts of its content.

Word dictionary

Every Hebrew and Greek word this study leans on, in everyday terms. Shaded rows are the anchor words the verdict rests on.

Strong	Word	Sounds like	Plain meaning	Times in Bible
H0120	אָדָם	adam	man	482
H0430	אֱלֹהִים	elohim	God	
H0582	אָנוּשׁ	enosh	human	
H1121	בֶּן	ben	son	
H1254	בָּרָא	bara	to create	46
H1818	דָּם	dam	blood	341
H1823	דְּמוּת	demuth	likeness	24
H1926	הָדָר	hadar	glory	
H2145	זָכָר	zakar	male	80

H3519	כְּבוֹד	kavod	glory	
H5347	נִקְבָּה	neqebah	female	22
H6213	עָשָׂה	asah	to make	
H6754	צֶלֶם	tselem	image	16
H7287	רָדָה	radah	to rule	18
G0341	ἀνακαινός	anakainoo	to renew	2
G0444	ἄνθρωπος	anthropos	a human	558
G1504	εἰκών	eikon	image	23
G1922	ἐπίγνωσις	epignosis	knowledge	20
G2316	θεός	theos	God	
G2672	καταράσμαι	kataaraomai	to curse	6
G2936	κτίζω	ktizo	to create	15
G3669	ὁμοίωσις	homoiosis	likeness	1

Plain meanings: STEP Bible brief lexicons TBESH (Hebrew) and TBESG (Greek), CC BY 4.0. Counts are occurrences across the 66-book canon.

Verdict rationale

Variant-robust: True · Pan-canonical: True

That humanity bears God's image is lexically decisive. tselem (H6754) and demuth (H1823) are predicated of adam at creation in Gen 1:26-27, with both nouns carrying the first-person-plural suffix (in our image, after our likeness). The same tselem grounds the murder prohibition in Gen 9:6 (causal ki), confirming the image persists after the fall and covers every human whose blood may be shed. Ps 8 restates it in royal idiom and Jas 3:9 uses a perfect participle (gegonotas) marking God's likeness (homoiosis) as an abiding condition of all people. The proposition is affirmed with high confidence. What the grammar leaves open is the CONTENT of the image, not its fact: tselem most often denotes a physical representation or statue and demuth a resemblance, and the coordinate jussive radah (and let them have dominion) is syntactically consequent to the image clause, not its definition, so substantive, relational, and functional readings all fit the words.

Scripture

Gen.1.26 · for · genre: narrative

Key terms. H6754 צֶלֶם, H1823 דְּמוּת, H0120 אָדָם, H7287A רָדָה.

Force. Divine deliberation (cohortative naaseh adam, let us make humanity) attaches two prepositional phrases to the creature: be-tsalmenu (in our image, tselem with 1cp suffix, morph HR/Ncmisc/Sp1bp) and ki-dmutenu (according to our likeness, demuth with 1cp suffix, HR/Ncfsc/Sp1bp). adam is the referent of the image. The dominion verb radah then appears as a coordinate waw plus jussive (we-yirdu, morph HC/Vqu3mp, and let them rule), a separate volitional clause consequent to the image, not an apposition that defines it. This is the exact grammatical seam where the content of the image is left open: the words establish that humanity IS the image but do not internally state whether that image is a substance, a relation, or the royal-representative function the following jussive expresses.

Gen.1.27 · for · genre: narrative

Key terms. H1254A בָּרָא, H6754 יָצַלַם, H2145 זָכָר, H5347 נִקְבָּה

Force. Triple bara of ha-adam, twice be-tselem elohim, closing with zakar uneqebah (male and female) and the plural object otam (them). The image is predicated of humanity in both sexes, with no qualifier of age, ability, ethnicity, or stage. The plural otam forecloses any reading that confines the image to one representative individual. The poetic structuring (three parallel verb clauses) is real Hebrew parallelism but carries no figurative trope from the closed enum.

Gen.9.6 · for · genre: law

Key terms. H6754 יָצַלַם, H0120 אָדָם, H1818 דָּם;

Force. Post-flood. The causal clause ki be-tselem elohim asah et-ha-adam (for in the image of God he made humanity) grounds the capital sanction against shedding human blood (dam). The causal ki ties the prohibition to an enduring image in post-fall humanity, demonstrating the image survives the fall and applies universally. This is the strongest single proof that the image is not forfeited by sin: it is the operative ground of a permanent legal protection.

Ps.8.5 · for · genre: wisdom

Key terms. H0120 אָדָם, H0582 אֲנוֹשׁ, H1121 בֶּן:

Force. enosh and ben-adam together name humanity in its frailty. The rhetorical question (what is humanity that you remember it) sets up the dignity declaration of v6. The pairing of adam and enosh broadens reference to humanity as a class. Notably Ps 8 does NOT use tselem or demuth, so it confirms the dignity theme without resolving the content question.

Ps.8.6 · for · genre: wisdom

Key terms. H3519 כְּבוֹד, H1926 הָדָר, H0430 אֱלֹהִים

Force. Humanity is crowned with kabod (glory) and hadar (honor) and made me-elohim (lacking little from God). The royal dignity vocabulary restates Gen 1:26-27 in regal idiom and, with the dominion that follows in vv7-9, lends weight to the functional royal-representative reading of the image, though it states dignity and rule rather than defining the image as such.

Jas.3.9 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G0444 ἄνθρωπος, G3669 ὁμοίωσις, G2672 καταράσθαι, G2316 θεός

Force. tous kath homoiosin theou gegonotas modifies anthropous as a perfect-participle predicate. The perfect gegonotas marks the likeness as a standing, completed-and-abiding condition of all humans, not a status forfeited by sin. James grounds an ethical prohibition (cursing fellow humans) on the universal likeness, the NT counterpart to Gen 9:6. homioiosis is a single-occurrence word in the canon, so its precise sense cannot be triangulated from Greek usage and must be read off the Gen 1:26 LXX background it echoes (kath homoiosin).

Col.3.10 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G0341 ἀνακαινώνω, G1922 ἐπιγινώσκis, G1504 εἰκών, G2936 κτίζω

Force. ton neon ton anakainoumenon eis epignosin kat eikona tou ktisantos. The present passive participle anakainoumenon (being renewed) presupposes an original eikon now disfigured and being restored, and kat eikona tou ktisantos echoes Gen 1:27 LXX (kat eikona theou). The pairing with epignosis (knowledge) supplies one concrete NT filling of the image (a rational, knowing capacity being renewed), which tilts toward but does not exhaust the substantive reading.

Cross references invoked

From	To	Source	Votes
Gen.9.6	Gen.1.26	tsk	1

Jas.3.9	Gen.1.26	tsk	1
Col.3.10	Gen.1.26	tsk	1
Ps.8.6	Gen.1.26	tsk	1
Gen.1.26	Gen.5.1	tsk	1
Gen.1.26	Gen.9.2	tsk	1
Gen.1.27	Isa.43.7	tsk	1
Gen.9.6	Exod.21.12	tsk	1
Gen.1.26	Gen.3.22	tsk	1

Complicating texts

Gen.5.3 · addressed

Adam fathers Seth bi-dmuto ke-tsalmu (in his likeness, according to his image), reusing both anchor nouns. Some read this as transmitting the divine image only through procreation, but the syntax simply parallels Gen 1:26 to mark Seth as fully human like his father. Since the same tselem and demuth are predicated of human-to-human resemblance, the verse confirms the image travels with humanity itself rather than being lost at the fall.

Gen.9.6 · addressed

This anchor is itself the resolution of a potential image-lost-at-the-fall reading: post-fall it predicates tselem elohim of every human whose blood may be shed, so the causal ki shows the image persists and is universal.

1Cor.11.7 · addressed

Paul calls man eikon kai doxa theou and woman doxa andros in a contextual argument about head coverings. eikon is the same lemma G1504 used in Col 3:10, but here it is deployed in a relational, glory-displaying register for a specific ecclesial argument, not to deny the creational image to woman, which Gen 1:27 explicitly extends to neqebah. The general anthropological image of Gen 1:26-27 and Jas 3:9 stands.

Ezek.1.26 · addressed

demuth (H1823) dominates Ezekiel as visionary resemblance (the likeness of a throne, the likeness as the appearance of a man). This shows demuth means resemblance or comparison generally, not a defined theological substance, which is exactly why the content of the image in Gen 1:26 is underdetermined by the word itself. It does not contradict the proposition; it explains the lexical room for divergent content readings.

Concordance traversed

H6754, H1823, H1254A, H0120, H7287A, H2145, H5347, H1818, H6213A, G1504, G3669, G0341, G1922, G2936, G0444, G2672

Variants

Verdict variant-sensitive: False · ECM status: n/a

OT anchors (Gen 1:26-27, Gen 9:6, Ps 8) lie outside CBGM scope. NT anchors (Jas 3:9, Col 3:10) lie outside the ingested ECM window (3 John 1.1 to 1.15), so `not_in_ecm_scope` holds. The known Jas 3:9 reading variation (kurion versus theon for the object of blessing) does not touch `tous kath homioisin theou gegonotas`, so the verdict is variant-robust on the image clause.

Hermeneutics

Primary method. grammatico-historical

Frameworks in play. substantive_image, relational_image, functional_royal_image

analogia scripturae invoked · progressive revelation factor

substantive_image: affirms · Reads the image as a created endowment of human nature (rationality, will, moral agency, capacity to know God). Strongest lexical support: Col 3:10 pairs the renewed eikon with epignosis (knowledge), and tselem of a statue connotes a standing, structural likeness. The proposition (humans bear the image) holds; this lens specifies the image as a substance the words permit but do not compel.

relational_image: affirms · Reads the image as the capacity and calling for relationship, signaled by the plural divine deliberation (let US make) and the male-and-female pairing of Gen 1:27, and by Jas 3:9 grounding how humans relate to one another. The proposition holds; this lens locates the image in relation rather than in an isolated faculty. The vocabulary neither confirms nor excludes it.

functional_royal_image: affirms · Reads the image as royal-representative office: humanity as God's vice-regent, supported by the coordinate jussive radah (and let them have dominion) immediately attached to the image clause, by tselem as the kind of representative statue a king set up, and by Ps 8 crowning humanity with glory and rule. The proposition holds; this lens treats the dominion mandate as the image's function. The grammar makes dominion consequent to the image, so this reading is strong but not forced.

All three lenses affirm the proposition that humanity bears God's image. They diverge only on the CONTENT of the image, which the anchor vocabulary underdetermines. The lexical evidence does not rank them, so each is recorded as affirming on its strongest reading.

Stem audit

verdict-preloaded: no

The stem asserts that all humans bear God's image and lists dignity, moral agency, rationality, and relational capacity. The bare proposition (humans are made in God's image, universally) is lexically clean and not preloaded. The enumerated capacities lean toward a substantive plus relational filling of the image, which the words of Gen 1:26-27 do not themselves specify; this is captured under the competing-lens treatment rather than as a stem distortion, since the core claim is testable on its own terms and is affirmed.

Citations

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morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	Jas.3.9
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	Col.3.10
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESH	CC-BY-4.0	yes	H6754
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESH	CC-BY-4.0	yes	H1823
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESH	CC-BY-4.0	yes	H7287A
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G1504
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G3669
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G0341

cross_ref	TSK	public_domain	yes	Gen.1.26
cross_ref	TSK	public_domain	yes	Gen.9.6
cross_ref	TSK	public_domain	yes	Jas.3.9
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